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ELECTION 2026 ANALYSIS

Dems’ desire for change clear

Voter frustration, not ideology, the ‘through line’ in results from Wisconsin, Minnesota, elsewhere

By **Joey Cappelletti**
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — Democrats remain mixed over what ideological direction the party should take. But across a series of closely

watched primaries, they are sending a clearer message about the party’s path forward: They want change.

In marquee Senate primaries in Michigan and Minnesota, progressive candidates defeated two members of Congress with signif-

icant backing from party leaders. Wisconsin voters narrowly rejected a democratic socialist but still chose a 40-year-old county executive who is seeking to become the state’s first Black governor.

And in Connecticut, voters ousted one of the longest-serving Democrats in Congress for a challenger who campaigned on generational change.

The results so far this month deliver no clear ideological mandate. Instead, they add to mounting evidence from this year’s primaries of a Democratic appetite for turnover that is cutting across the party’s traditional divisions.

“The through line between these races isn’t ideology. It’s impatience with this political system that feels disconnected from the urgency

voters feel,” said Lis Smith, a national Democratic strategist. “The demand for change is much broader than the demand for socialism.”

The immediate challenge for Democrats is whether they can harness the frustration fueling revolts against their own party and

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BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

STEEL AND RESOLVE

Guests take a look at a beam from the World Trade Center on Wednesday at the Engine 18 fire station in Chicago’s Near West Side during a tour commemorating the 25th anniversary of the 9/11 attacks. The event was part of the Tunnel to Towers Foundation’s “Steel Across America” tour, which is bringing the 21-foot beam salvaged from the south tower to more than 35 cities nationwide. Attendees were encouraged to climb atop a platform and touch the beam, which organizers called a “symbol of resilience.” **Chicagoland, Page A3**

ELECTION 2026
SCHOOL BOARD

SEIU puts \$1.1M into race amid CTU feud

By **Kate Armanini**
and **Alice Yin**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SEIU Illinois State Council transferred \$1.1 million to a new independent expenditure group last week, gearing up to spend big in Chicago’s school board race as the rift with its onetime ally turned rival, the Chicago Teachers Union, escalates publicly.

The contribution — made last week to super PAC Brighter Futures Chicago — came days before CTU Vice President Jackson Potter and SEIU Illinois Executive Director Anthony Driver traded blows on a social media exchange over Chicago Public Schools’ controversial budget. Driver created Brighter Futures Chicago last month.

The two progressive, politically powerful unions helped carry Mayor Brandon Johnson into office. But last year, their relationship blew up amid a

See **SEIU** on Page A5



The Bally’s Chicago casino construction site on Wednesday. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Aldermen tell Bally’s to keep digging despite video gaming terminal fight

By **Robert Channick**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Responding to a construction slowdown by Bally’s Chicago over the city’s authorization of video gambling terminals, a group of 27 aldermen issued a demand letter to the casino company Wednesday calling for a public hearing and the resumption of the full development project.

The letter, sent to Christo-

pher Jewett, senior vice president of corporate development for Bally’s, challenges the legality of the construction pause on the hotel and other nongaming amenities at the \$1.7 billion casino complex going up in the River West neighborhood.

“Chicago did not enter into an agreement for a casino floor alone,” the aldermen wrote. “It entered into an agreement for the complete development

Bally’s promised to build. The Council expects Bally’s to deliver that project and expects the administration to enforce that commitment.”

Bally’s Chicago issued a reset notice Saturday to the Chicago Community Builders Collective, a general contracting partnership overseeing the casino complex construction, putting everything

See **BALLY’S** on Page A2

Standby billing cost Ill. millions

Audit: IEMA paid contractor for 469K hours without work

By **Jeremy Gorner**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — A state agency under Gov. JB Pritzker’s purview paid a Kansas-based staffing contractor \$78.5 million for time its employees spent on standby rather than actually working, part of a broader failure to properly oversee contractor billing, according to a report issued by a state watchdog.

The report released Tuesday from Illinois Auditor General Christopher Meister’s office found the Illinois Emergency Management Agency-Office of Homeland Security did not provide proof to auditors that it could determine how many contractors it needed or to verify that its contractors were billing the state accurately. The agency has been responsible for helping coordinate the state’s response to major emergencies, including the COVID-19 pandemic and the influx of migrants three years ago to the Chicago area.

The \$78.5 million in standby billing — a practice known as “standdown,” under which contractors are paid even when not actively working — came from Favorite Healthcare Staffing, a national employment agency based in Kansas that also helped Chicago respond to the migrant influx and contributed to the city’s multimillion-dollar

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INSIDE



TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Snap into place

Quarterback Caleb Williams and center Garrett Bradbury work to build a relationship for the Bears. **Sports**

‘A POSITIVE PRESENCE’

CTA to add crisis intervention and community violence prevention teams. **Business**

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